

AUTODESK HOMESTYLER

A web app that allows users to redesign their home with the simplicity of drag-and-drop.

Autodesk Homestyler is a free web app, also available as a Chrome extension. It's a very handy application for designing and laying out the rooms of your home, and, if you were in America, you would be able to directly place orders for the items you selected to furnish your designed home.

The software also allows you to share your designs online on sites such as Facebook as well as export the design to professional software such as AutoCAD.

System requirements

It's recommended that you use a browser such as Firefox or Internet Explorer 9 that supports hardware acceleration of Flash content. Since the software is also a bit resource-heavy and will get bogged down on netbooks and low-speed internet connections.

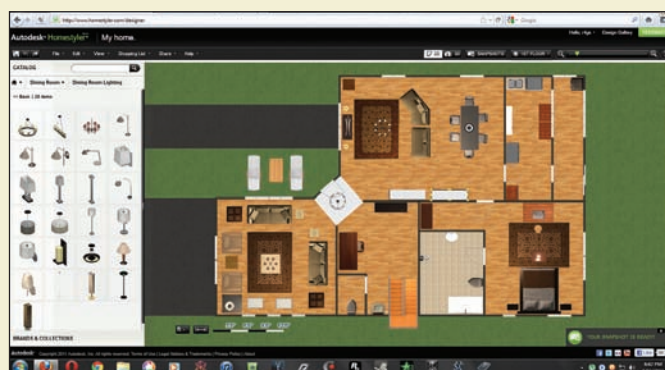
Getting started

Having a rough sketch or diagram of the overall design before you begin will get things rolling in the right direction. You could run into unexpected problems if you try to modify your design later on.

You can also lay out the floor areas first and add the rooms on top of them. This helps as you'll have a general idea about where the rooms will go and so avoid overlapping walls.



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2D design view

The interface

The interface is very simple. Everything is on an on-screen panel and you just drag whatever you need onto the main canvas. While all the items are classified based on various criteria, it's often easier to just search for what you need as eve-

rything is not necessarily where you expect it to be.

The layout

Basic room placement is quite easily done as the rooms snap to 90-degree angles. It's when you try to create angles and other shapes that you can run into

trouble. The software doesn't provide a tool to measure angles accurately so you had better delve into the deep recesses of your mind to dig out what little trigonometric knowledge you may have left. The dimensions are shown on the fly however, so you'll always know what your wall dimensions are.

There are various tools available to nudge the walls to certain shapes, but it sometimes works out better when you split the wall and manipulate the axis and length yourself.

Placement rules

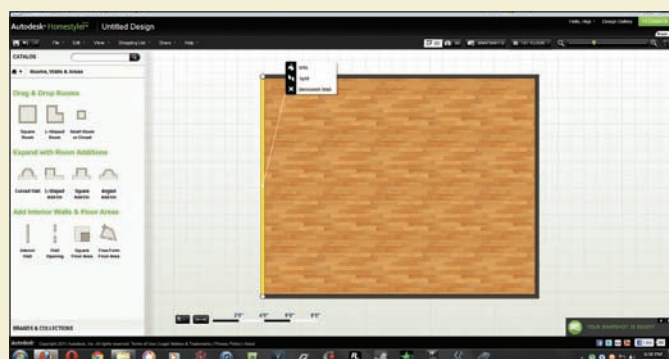
Homestyler has a feature called "placement rules". This feature basically ensures that everything you place in your design is following the laws of physics. For example, without placement rules, you wouldn't be able to place, say, a pot on a table. The pot would end up on the floor, clipping through the table.

You can enable placement rules by going to Edit > Edit Preferences and checking the box marked "Enable Placement Rules".

Placement rules can make moving large objects such as sofas around a room a challenge. This can be overcome by just holding down the [Shift] key while moving the object.

Furnish your home

Furniture is classified into living room, dining room, etc. for quick access so you can choose accordingly.



Basic layout



3D design view